

The background features black silhouettes of birds and tree branches against a white background. In the top left, three birds are in flight. In the top right, a bird is perched on a branch. On the left side, a large tree branch extends upwards with two birds perched on it. On the right side, another tree branch extends upwards with a bird perched on it. In the bottom right corner, a bird is in flight.

THE BIRD AND THE BRANCHES

PITA KHANGERN



HOW CAN GAME MECHANICS AND
DESIGN ELEMENTS TRANSLATE
PHYSICAL SENSORY EXPERIENCE
INTO ALTERBIOGRAPHY?

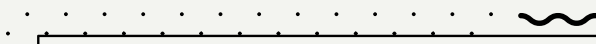




[LINK - Studio 2 Abstract Draft](#)

[LINK - Studio 2 Milestone Video](#)

[LINK - Studio 2 Milestone Presentaion](#)



ABSTRACT



Psychological games often explore mental states through narrative and visuals, or only through game mechanics. What if we could piece together all the pieces to create a physical sensory experience, allowing players to feel their mental state and build their own alterbiography?

The Bird and The Branches is a 3D psychological game that puts players in the role of a bird flying to explore a world of the mind depicted through five tree environments. Players will confront emotional states conveyed through color, sound, and gameplay instability, inviting them to create alterbiography — their own interpretation of inner mental experiences — through playing.

This project uses Calleja's Alterbiography theory as a framework for designing the experience, dividing the player's journey into five stages based on the Kübler-Ross model to tell the story of confronting emotions and accepting one's inner shadow, leading the process of individuation according to Carl Jung's theory.

This project explores the potential of using visual, audio, and control mechanics together to convey psychological states — especially the transitions between emotional states and the process of individuation — through physical sensory experience and allows players to create their own alterbiography.





ALTERBIOGRAPHY

“An alterbiography is the active construction of an ongoing story that develops through interaction with the game world’s topography, inhabitants, objects, and game rules and simulated environmental properties. Not every assemblage of sign and code is likely to be an equally inspiring source of story generation for every player. The formation of an alterbiography is thus dependent on the disposition of the individual. Where one player might find that a game environment provides a stimulating narrative, another may not:” (Calleja, 2011, p. 127).



5 STAGES OF GRIEF

DENIAL

"Denial functions as a buffer after unexpected shocking news, allows the patient to collect himself and, with time, mobilize other, less radical defenses." — p. 36

ANGER

"When the first stage of denial cannot be maintained any longer, it is replaced by feelings of anger, rage, envy, and resentment. The logical next question becomes: 'Why me?'" — p. 44–45

BARGAINING

"The bargaining is really an attempt to postpone; it has to include a prize offered 'for good behavior,' it also sets a self-imposed deadline... and it includes an implicit promise that the patient will not ask for more if this one postponement is granted." — p. 72

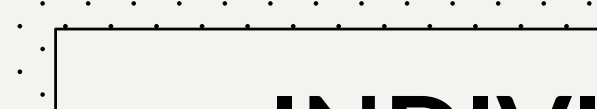
ACCEPTANCE

"Acceptance should not be mistaken for a happy stage. It is almost void of feelings. It is as if the pain had gone, the struggle is over, and there comes a time for 'the final rest before the long journey.'" — p. 100

DEPRESSION

"If he is allowed to express his sorrow he will find a final acceptance much easier... In the preparatory grief there is no or little need for words.

It is much more a feeling that can be mutually expressed and is often done better with a touch of a hand, a stroking of the hair, or just a silent sitting together." — p. 77

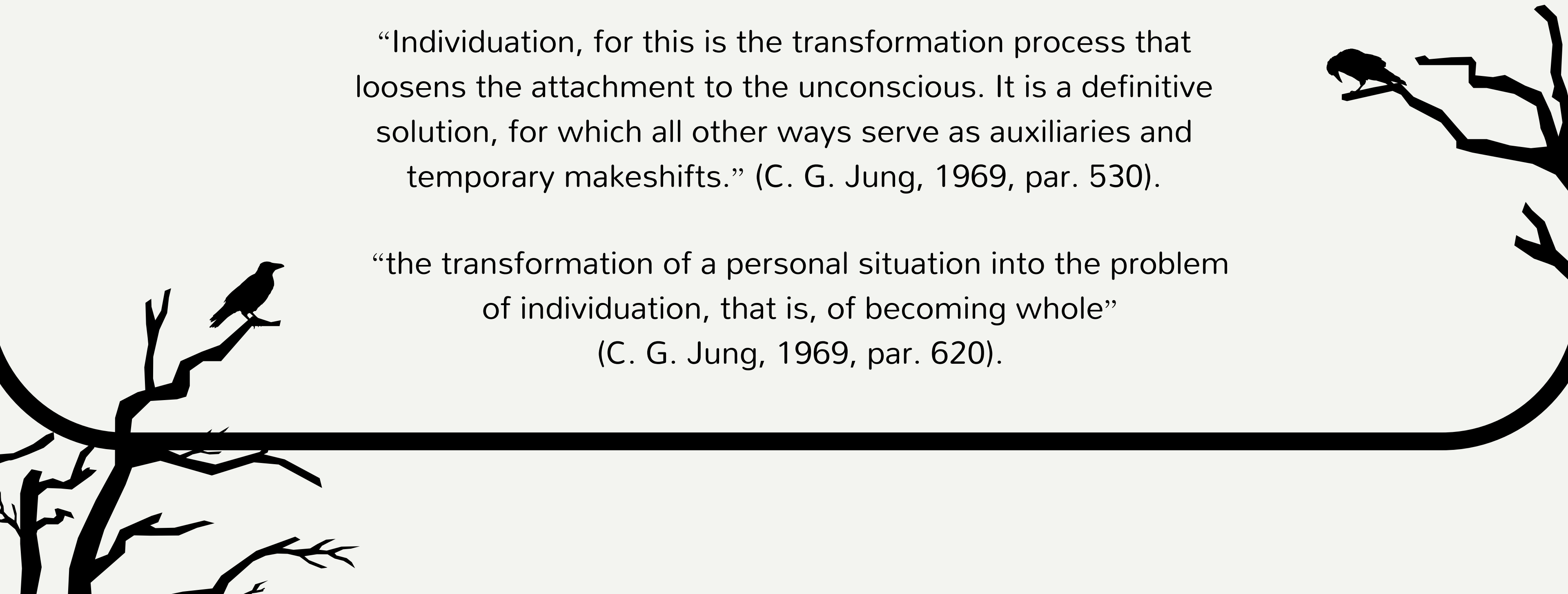


INDIVIDUATION



“Individuation, for this is the transformation process that loosens the attachment to the unconscious. It is a definitive solution, for which all other ways serve as auxiliaries and temporary makeshifts.” (C. G. Jung, 1969, par. 530).

“the transformation of a personal situation into the problem of individuation, that is, of becoming whole”
(C. G. Jung, 1969, par. 620).

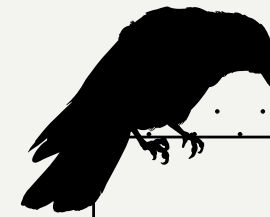




METHODS



- Theories as Framework - I used Calleja's Alterbiography + Kübler-Ross 5 Stages + Jungian Individuation as the design structure for each stage.
- Game Design - I designed the mechanics for each stage to reflect emotional states, such as inverted control and anger typing.
- Visual & Audio Design - I designed the colours and sound pitching of each stage to connect with the emotion being conveyed. For sound, I did collaboration with a sound designer
- Prototyping - I created a prototype in Unity and improve it based on weekly feedback and reflection.



REFLECTION

Throughout this project, I significantly refined my inquiry to create the best possible player experience. I started by shifting the focus from control instability to translating physical sensory experiences and finally applied alterbiography to create feelings that players could interpret and create in their own way. I learned that game mechanics must be continuously questioned and iterated to better serve the player experience. For example, I asked myself if a button mashing system truly allows players to interpret the game in their own way, and what if we switched to a typing system that allows for more diverse interpretations. This iterative process reinforced that translating psychological states into physical sensory experience is not only possible through mechanics, but requires the cohesion of visuals, sound, and design working together. Moving forward, I want to let others playtest the game, refine it, and improve it smoothly before continuing with the remaining stages in Studio 3.





REFERENCES



Calleja, G. (2011). In-game: From immersion to incorporation. MIT Press.

Jung, C. G. (1969). Archetypes and the collective unconscious. In G. Adler & R. F. C. Hull (Eds.), The collected works of C. G. Jung (Vol. 9, Part 1). Princeton University Press.

Kübler-Ross, E. (1969). On Death and Dying. Macmillan.